

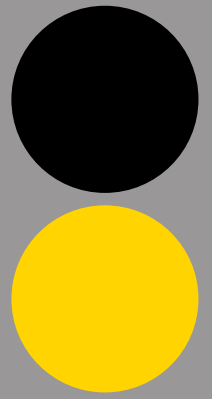


EXPAND YOUR WORLD

GERMAN

LEVEL 1

LESSON 1



Vocab

Good morning!	Guten Morgen!
Good day!	Guten Tag!
Good evening!	Guten Abend!
Good night!	Gute Nacht!
Have a nice day!	Schönen Tag noch!
to go	gehen
to dance	tanzen
to sleep	schlafen

Grammar

Welcome to your very first German lesson! If you haven't read the Introduction to German I yet, make sure to go read it now before continuing on. The introduction will explain how the lessons are formatted and how you should complete the lessons. Remember to refer back to the pronunciation guide in the introduction to help you know how to say words correctly.

In this lesson, we are going to kick it off by learning some very basic German grammar that will get you speaking some very simple sentences right off the bat! Be sure to make flashcards out of the vocabulary list and start memorizing those high-frequency words.

The Subject Pronouns

Pronouns are little words that act as quick & easy substitutes for nouns. We use them so we don't have to say nouns over and over again. See the example below.

"John went to the store. John bought apples. John ate the apples. John came home."

"John went to the store. He bought apples. He ate them. He came home."

The pronoun "he" replaced the repetitive use of the name "John", and the pronoun "them" replaced repeating "apples". Pronouns make sentences shorter & concise.

The term **subject pronouns** refers to the pronouns when they're used as the subject of the sentence. They are the doers of the action.

The subject pronouns in English: *I, you, he, she, it, we, you (all), they*

These subject pronouns also exist in German! Even though these words are not part of your main vocabulary list, you should still add them to your flashcards and try to memorize them going forward.

Subject Pronouns	
I	ich
you (singular/informal)	du
he	er
she	sie
it	es
we	wir
you all (plural/informal)	ihr
they	sie

Verb Conjugation

In most languages, verbs have to be conjugated when they're used in sentences. **Conjugation** is changing a verb's form to match how the verb is being used. In English, we conjugate verbs, too. Verbs are required conjugation when used with certain subjects or in certain tenses (timeframes).

We mostly conjugate verbs in English for tense (present, past, future, etc.).

Examples of conjugating for tense:

I see → I saw → I have seen

I play → I played → I have played

The only time we conjugate for subject regularly in English is when the subject is a singular noun or the pronouns “he”, “she”, or “it” in the present tense.

Examples of conjugating for subject:

I see → he seesu

I play → she playsu

In German, a verb has to conjugate to match both the subject & the tense. Because of this, there are many forms of one verb. The good news is, German has pretty simple conjugation endings to learn.

The best way to learn the different conjugations in German is to learn by tense. Each tense has its own pattern to follow for the different subjects. In this lesson, we are going to learn the present tense.

The Present Tense

The **present tense** is used to describe actions that are occurring now or habitually. In English, the present tense has three different forms:

Examples of present tenses in English:

I go / I am going / I do go

He runs / He is running / He does run

All three of these present tenses are combined into one present tense in German! This means there is one way in German to say all three of those sentences in the examples above. For you linguists out there, this means that German does not have a separate present progressive tense.

Verbs in German conjugate differently in each tense depending on the subject (the doer of the verb). The present tense in German is conjugated using simple endings that you add to the end of the **verb stem**. Let's first look at how to find a verb's stem.

Most verbs in German end in “-en” (some end in just “-n”). This unconjugated form of the verb is called the **infinitive**. All you have to do to form the verb stem is cut off this “-en” ending.

Verb Infinitive	Verb Stem
gehen (to go)	geh- (go)
tanzen (to dance)	tanz- (dance)
schlafen (to sleep)	schlaf- (sleep)

Now that you have the verb stem, you can form the present tense of the verb by adding the correct present tense ending. Each pronoun in German provides a specific ending to the verb stem. Let's learn those endings.

Present Tense Verb Endings	
ich	-e
du	-st
er	-t
sie	
es	
wir	-en
ihr	-t
sie	-en

Let’s see step-by-step how to conjugate a verb in the present tense. We will first conjugate with the pronoun “I” or “ich” using the verb “gehen”.

STEP 1: Take the infinitive	STEP 2: Form the Verb Stem	STEP 3: Add the pronoun & its present tense ending
gehen (to go)	geh- (go)	ich gehe I go / I am going

Present Tense: GEHEN (TO GO)

ich gehe	I go / I am going / I do go
du gehst	you go / you are going / you do go
er geht	he goes / he is going / he does go
sie geht	she goes / she is going / she does go
es geht	it goes / it is going / it does go
wir gehen	we go / we are going / we do go
ihr geht	you (all) go / you (all) are going / you (all) do go
sie gehen	they go / they are going / they do go

Stem-Changing Verbs

Some verbs in German are referred to as **stem-changing verbs**. These verbs have a vowel change in the verb stem that must occur when they're conjugated in the present tense with the singular pronouns "*du, er, sie, & es*". In other words, with all *singular* pronouns except for "ich".

The different stem changes that you'll come across are:

"a" → "ä"

"e" → "i"

"e" → "ie"

You must memorize which verbs do this stem change. In future lessons, we will indicate if a verb has a stem change and which one they use. The verb "schlafen", which means "to sleep", is one of these stem-changing verbs. It uses the change "a" to "ä". This is how we will teach these verbs:

schlafen (a → ä)

to sleep

Let's see this verb conjugated fully in the present tense.

Present Tense: SCHLAFEN a → ä (TO SLEEP)

ich schlafe	I sleep / I am sleeping / I do sleep
du schläfst	you sleep / you are sleeping / you do sleep
er schläft	he sleeps / he is sleeping / he does sleep
sie schläft	she sleeps / she is sleeping / she does sleep
es schläft	it sleeps / it is sleeping / it does sleep
wir schlafen	we sleep / we are sleeping / we do sleep
ihr schlaft	you sleep / you are sleeping / you do sleep
sie schlafen	they sleep / they are sleeping / they do sleep

That's the end of this lesson! After the first few lessons, you'll also have reading sections to complete. For now, the examples in this lesson will count as your readings until you've built up a few more grammar concepts. Congratulations on completing your very first lesson of German!